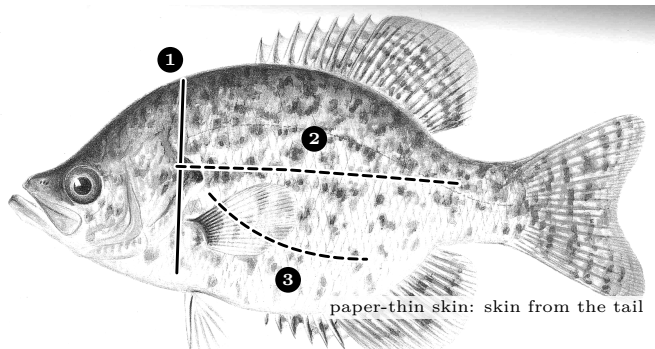


Cooking Black Crappie

Pomoxis nigromaculatus — in the kitchen

The mildest fillet in the lake



Calico Bass; Strawberry Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The mildest and whitest of the panfish, with a slightly larger flake than bluegill. Many people rate it above every other panfish.
Texture	Soft, delicate, large-flaked for its size. Wants a gentle hand.
Best size	10 in and up. Crappie are thin fish, so a 10 in crappie yields less than a 10 in bass.
Yield	About 24%. Two fillets of roughly 2 oz from a 10 in fish.
Skin	Thin and tears easily. Skin from the tail with a firm grip.
Winter fish	Crappie taken through the ice are the best of the year — cold water firms the flesh noticeably.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

The mouth	The membrane is famously thin, which is a fishing problem rather than a cleaning one — but it also means the head end tears easily under the knife. Cut, do not pull.
Rib cage	Fine and easily lifted.
No pin bones	Clean fillet once the ribs are out.
Handle gently	Crappie flesh is the softest here. Do not stack fillets under weight.

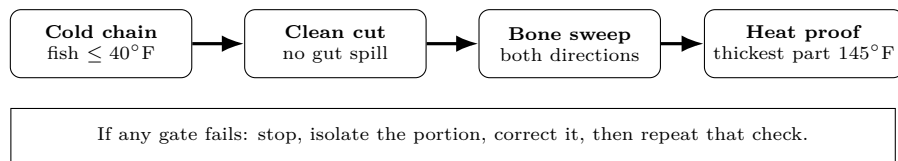
Cooking it

Method	How
Lightly fried	Seasoned flour only — a heavy batter buries a fish this mild. Butter, medium heat, two minutes a side.
Broiled with butter	Fillets on a buttered tray, paprika, lemon, six to eight minutes under a hot broiler. Nothing else needed.
Fish chowder	Crappie's softness is an asset in a chowder. Potato, onion, bacon, cream, and the fillets added in the last four minutes so they flake through.

Do not batter it heavily

Crappie is the mildest thing you will catch in these lakes, and the standard beer batter that suits walleye completely overwhelms it. Flour, butter and lemon. If you cannot taste the fish, the recipe is wrong for it.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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